

British premieres

The Dvořáks' marriage, in the meantime, was happy and fruitful; six of their nine children survived. Anna was described by Dvořák's friend Tchaikovsky as "a simple, likable woman and a splendid housewife." Yet Dvořák's affection for his sister-in-law haunted him. The slow movement of his Cello Concerto (1894–1895) was a tribute to her after her death, quoting from one of his songs of which she had been fond. "If I had known it was possible to write such a concerto for the cello, I would have tried it myself," Brahms said after hearing the work.

The concerto, like his Symphony No. 7 (1885) and Requiem (1890), enjoyed its world premiere in Britain, where Dvořák was extremely popular and influential. Composers including Edward Elgar and Samuel Coleridge-Taylor owed him a major debt.

In 1891, Dvořák—by now a composer of eight symphonies, recipient of honorary doctorates, and professor of composition at the Prague Conservatory—was offered the chance to become director of a new National Conservatory in New York. Here, his effective employer, the philanthropist Jeannette Thurber, had another task in mind. Dvořák had created a recognizably Bohemian style, a musical national identity comparable to Grieg for Norway or Liszt for Hungary. Such styles were fashionable, influential, and a source of national pride. Thurber hoped Dvořák might concoct a US equivalent.